

6.1 OpenOffice.org

6.1.1 Introduction

Efficiency is the mantra everywhere today and at the same time customers also want the options available to be reasonable. In such a scenario if you were to offer a product for free then you can be sure that there would be many takers for it. OpenOffice is one such product which suits not only the free criteria, but it is also a very worthy competitor for Microsoft Office. Coming from the Sun Microsystems stable, OpenOffice also known as 'OOo', has been in development for three years and can be downloaded from the official Web site: <http://www.openoffice.org/>.

Installation does not take much time and is pretty smooth. One small hiccup that you may face while installation is that it asks for the presence of Java on your system, if it is not there already. Though it is not a compulsion, OOo recommends Java for better performance. OOo comprises of 'Writer'—the word processor, 'Calc'—the spreadsheet, 'Impress' for presentations and 'Draw' for diagrams. Let's look at each of these separately

6.1.2 OOo's Writer

The interface looks pretty similar to Microsoft Word. The toolbars on the top of the document list all the functions similar to Word. One feature that I particularly liked about OOo Writer is the 'Autocomplete' feature. What this does is that it guesses which word the user wants to type and guesses it even before the user can complete typing. If it is actually what you want to use then you just need to press [Enter] and the complete word appears, else just go on typing what you want without bothering with what the application has to offer.

Another feature that's very useful is the ability to export your document in Writer as an Acrobat PDF file, which is absent in word. However the much useful option in MS Word which offers you correct spellings of incorrectly typed words is absent here. Some things that are simple in MS Word become a little complicated when it comes to Writer. This includes changing the font type which has to be done